IELTS LISTENING

My 3-Week Plan

Listening skills + spelling, from 25 to 30+

Now	about **25/40** (band 6.0)
Target	**30+/40** (band 7.0+)
Main problems	Part 3 feels fast · spelling mistakes
Daily time	about 75 minutes

Week 1
4–10 Nov
Find the problems, fix the ear

Week 2
11–17 Nov
Part 3 & 4 power week

Week 3
18–24 Nov
Exam simulation

Mocks
25–30 Nov
2–3 unseen tests

Exam
December
Band 7+

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How to use this guide: read Sections 0–5 once in the first two days. After that you only need Section 6 (daily routine), Section 7 (today's task) and Section 10 (log and tracker). Print the pages of Section 10, or copy them into your notebook.

0 Know Your Target

Correct answers	Band
23–25	6.0 ← you are here
26–29	6.5
30–31	**7.0 ← target**
32–34	7.5
35–36	8.0

You need 5–7 more correct answers. Most learners at your level find them here:

Where the marks come from	Marks to win back
Spelling, plurals, word limits	2–3
Part 3: getting lost, distractors	2–3
Part 4: missing quick note answers	1–2

You do not need to become a new listener. You need to **stop losing easy marks** and **stay with the audio in Part 3**.

1 What You Need

Item	Notes
Cambridge IELTS 10–14	You have the PDFs in `Cambridge eBooks/`. The **audioscripts are at the back** of each book.
The audio files	Not in your folder. You need the audio for each book.
A notebook	Two sections: **Mistake Log** (Section 10) and **Spelling**
Headphones	Use them for all practice
A phone timer	For full tests and dictation

Which tests to use (follow this exactly)

Use	Tests
Training (Weeks 1–3)	Cambridge 10 Tests 1–4, Cambridge 11 Tests 1–4, Cambridge 12 Tests 1–2
Dictation and shadowing	Audio from tests you **have already done** (never unseen tests)
🔒 **Mock tests: do not touch**	Cambridge 13 and 14 (all tests). If you have Cambridge 17–19, use those for mocks instead because they are closest to the real exam.

> Keep the mock tests **unseen**. A mock test you have already heard gives you a false score.

2 The 6 Tools

Every day uses some of these six tools. Learn them once here.

Tool A Mistake Log (5 min, after every test)

Write **every** wrong answer in the log (Section 10) and give it **one reason**:

Code	Reason
SP	Spelling (I heard it but spelled it wrong)
GR	Grammar: plural -s, -ed, wrong word form
WL	Broke the word limit
DIS	Distractor: I wrote the first answer, but the speaker changed it
LOST	Lost my place and missed the answer
HEAR	Couldn't hear the word clearly
VOC	Didn't know the word

At the end of each week, count the codes. **The biggest code is next week's focus.**

Tool B Sentence Dictation (15 min)

This trains your ear for fast, connected speech and also trains your spelling.

1. Choose **2–3 minutes** of Part 3 or Part 4 audio from a test you have done.
2. Play **one sentence**, then pause.
3. Write every word. You can replay it **up to 3 times**.
4. If a word is still unclear, write `____` and move on.
5. Check against the audioscript. Mark each mistake:
   - **Didn't hear it** → play that spot again 3 times while looking at the script
   - **Spelled it wrong** → add it to your spelling list
   - **Didn't know it** → learn it
6. Play the whole clip once more while reading the script.

> ⚠️ Stop after 15–20 minutes. Dictation is tiring, and a tired brain learns very little.

Tool C Spelling Practice (10 min)

Follow the routine in `Writing/IELTS_Spelling_Fix_List.md` (Look, Say, Cover, Write, Check). Each day: **3 words from the Listening Word Bank (Section 5) + 2 of your own mistakes**.

Tool D Transcript Method (20–30 min)

This is the best training for Part 3.

1. Do the section under test conditions and mark it.
2. Open the audioscript. For **every** question, highlight:
    - where the answer is
    - the **paraphrase** (the question says "*cost*", the speaker says "*it's not cheap*")
    - the **distractor** (the wrong answer that was mentioned first)
3. Play the audio again **with** the script.
4. Play it again **without** the script. You should now hear every answer.

Tool E Shadowing (5 min)

Play one sentence, pause, and **say it aloud**, copying the speed and the way words join together. Do 2–3 minutes of audio. This teaches your brain the real speed of English, so fast speech stops surprising you.

Tool F Full Test (40 min + 10 min)

Strict exam conditions:

- No pausing, no replaying
- Write on an answer sheet in **CAPITAL LETTERS**
- **10 minutes to transfer** answers at the end (paper test)
- Then mark it and fill in the Mistake Log

> **Computer test?** Type your answers during the audio and keep only **2 minutes** at the end for checking. Practise the same way.

3 Part-by-Part Strategy

Part 1: Conversation, form completion (aim for 9–10/10)

This is where spelling and numbers decide your score.

- **Spelled names:** practise the letters that sound alike: **A / E / I · G / J · B / P / V · M / N · S / F · Q / U**
- **"Double"** means write the letter twice: "*double L*" = LL.
- **Numbers: 13 / 30 · 14 / 40 · 15 / 50**. In 13 the stress is at the end (thir-**TEEN**), and in 30 it is at the start (**THIR**-ty).
- **Corrections:** "*It's 15… oh no, sorry, 16.*" The **last** answer counts.
- **Prices and dates:** write *£15.50* or *15 March*. Both *March 15* and *15 March* are accepted.

Part 2: Monologue, maps and multiple choice (aim for 8/10)

- **Maps:** before the audio, find **where you are standing** ("*You are here*") and the entrance. Learn these words: *opposite, next to, behind, in front of, at the end of, on the corner, to the left/right of, beyond, past, between.*
- Follow the speaker with your pencil on the map.

Part 3: Discussion (aim for 6–7/10, now about 4–5)

See Section 4 below: the full Part 3 system.

Part 4: Lecture, note completion (aim for 7–8/10)

- There is **no break** in the middle. Read all 10 questions before it starts.
- The notes follow the lecture in order. Use the **headings** as signposts.
- Listen for signpost phrases: "*Firstly…*", "*Moving on to…*", "*Another factor is…*", "*However…*", "*The main reason…*", "*To sum up…*"
- Usually **one word only**, and often an academic word, so spelling matters a lot here.

Question types

Type	How to do it
Form / note completion	Predict the word type (noun? number? plural?). Check the word limit.
Multiple choice	All 3 options are usually mentioned. Cross out each one as it is rejected.
Choose TWO	The two answers can come in any order, and the speakers may reject options between them.
Matching	The options list (A–G) is in random order; the questions are in order. Keep your eyes on the questions, not the options list.
Map / diagram	Find the starting point first. Follow with your pencil.

4 The Part 3 System

Part 3 is not faster than the other parts. It **feels** faster because 2–3 people are discussing, changing their minds, and disagreeing. The answer is almost never the first idea you hear.

Before the audio (use every second of reading time)

1. Underline **1–2 keywords** in each question.
2. Underline **who** the question is about: the student, the tutor, or both.
3. For multiple choice, think of other ways each option could be said.
4. Notice question words like *main*, *most*, *first*, *disagree*, *both*.

While listening: the 2-question rule

Keep your eyes on two questions: the current one and the next. If you hear the answer to the next question, you have missed the current one. **Leave it blank, move on, and guess at the end.** Never chase a lost answer. That is how one missed answer becomes three.

Listen for signal phrases (this is where answers change)

Signal	Phrases
Rejecting an idea	*I'm not sure about that · Actually… · That won't work because… · Yes, but… · The trouble is… · I don't think so · That's not really…*
Agreeing / deciding	*That's a good point · Exactly · Let's go with… · So we agree that… · I think you're right · OK, so that's settled*
Changing mind	*On second thought… · Actually, maybe we should… · Now that you mention it…*
Emphasis (answer is coming)	*The main problem was… · What really surprised me was… · The most important thing is…*

The 4 distractor traps

Trap	Example
Suggested then rejected	*"We could use a survey." "Hmm, that would take too long. Interviews are better."* → interviews
Past vs now	*"We used to meet on Mondays, but now it's Thursdays."* → Thursdays
Not X but Y	*"It's not the cost that worries me, it's the time."* → time
Correction	*"The deadline is the 10th… no, the tutor changed it to the 12th."* → 12th

Part 3 training each day

Do one Part 3 with **Tool D (Transcript Method)**, and in the script, **highlight every signal phrase in a different colour**. After 10–15 Part 3s you will start to hear these phrases automatically.

5 Spelling for Listening

The rules for answers

- Wrong spelling = **wrong answer**. No half marks.
- British and American spellings are both accepted (*colour / color*).
- **Write in CAPITAL LETTERS** on the paper test. This is allowed, it makes letters clear, and you never worry about capitals for names.
- **Plurals matter.** If you hear "*tables*", writing *table* is wrong.
- Hyphenated words count as **one** word (*part-time*).
- Numbers can be written as digits (*15*, not *fifteen*).

Your biggest spelling problem

In your own mistake list, **most errors are weak vowels**. You write the sound you hear, but in English the unstressed "uh" sound can be spelled *a, e, i, o* or *u* (*similer → similar, santance → sentence, grammer → grammar*).

Fix: learn a "spelling voice." Say every hard word in your head the way it is *spelled*, not the way it sounds:

Word	Say it like this
Wednesday	**Wed-nes-day**
February	**Feb-ru-ar-y**
vegetable	**veg-e-ta-ble**
comfortable	**com-fort-a-ble**
temperature	**tem-per-a-ture**
library	**lib-rar-y**
separate	**sep-a-rate** (there is *a rat* in separate)
environment	**en-vi-ron-ment**
government	**gov-ern-ment**
restaurant	**res-tau-rant**

Listening-specific spelling rules

Rule	Examples
Plural -es after s, x, ch, sh, and some o-words	buses, boxes, matches, dishes, potatoes, tomatoes
Consonant + y → ies	facility → facil**ities**, activity → activ**ities**, library → librar**ies**
f / fe → ves	shelf → shel**ves**, knife → kni**ves**, life → li**ves**
Double letters	accommodation (cc, mm), committee (mm, tt, ee), address, questionnaire (nn), recommend (one c, mm), opportunity (pp), beginning (nn)

Rule	Examples
i before e, except after c	believe, field, achieve · but rec**ei**pt, rec**ei**ve, c**ei**ling
Silent letters	rece**i**p**t**, **k**nowledge, **w**rite, i**s**land, Wedn**e**sday, colum**n**

Listening Word Bank (learn 3 a day)

These words appear again and again in IELTS Listening answers.

Topic	Words
Days & months	Wednesday, Thursday, Saturday, February, August
Places & buildings	library, laboratory, museum, gallery, theatre, centre, restaurant, cafeteria, stadium, hospital, pharmacy, apartment, reception, entrance, corridor, basement, cathedral
Accommodation & forms	accommodation, address, surname, postcode, occupation, nationality, signature, application, reference, licence, insurance, deposit, receipt, guarantee
Money	payment, discount, refund, budget, salary, purchase, cheque, rent, fee, cash
Travel	journey, departure, arrival, luggage, passenger, vehicle, ferry, tunnel, destination, itinerary, reservation, schedule, souvenir, excursion, brochure, platform
Study	lecture, seminar, tutorial, assignment, dissertation, questionnaire, research, survey, statistics, bibliography, presentation, semester, campus, graduate, experiment, analysis
Health	medicine, nutrition, vitamin, protein, exercise, muscle, injury, allergy, diet, symptom, temperature
Nature & environment	environment, pollution, climate, habitat, species, conservation, recycling, wildlife, desert, glacier, volcano, drought, fertiliser, agriculture, coast, island, vegetation
Science & history (Part 4)	technology, equipment, frequency, oxygen, carbon, evidence, theory, architecture, archaeology, sculpture, colony, ancient, mineral, population
Everyday hard words	necessary, convenient, comfortable, available, beginner, colleague, committee, business, especially, recommend, opportunity, competition, separate, government

> **Also add every SP word from your Mistake Log** to your spelling list. Your own mistakes are worth more than any word bank.

6 The Daily Routine (about 75 minutes)

Order	Time	Tool
1	10 min	**C** Spelling (3 word-bank words + 2 own mistakes)
2	15 min	**B** Sentence dictation
3	35–45 min	**Main task of the day** (see the plan below)
4	5 min	**E** Shadowing
5	5 min	**A** Mistake Log + tick today in the tracker

Extra listening (optional, 15–20 min while travelling or relaxing): BBC Learning English *6 Minute English* (week 1), then BBC Radio 4 or TED talks (weeks 2–3). Choose programmes with **2–3 people discussing**: that is free Part 3 practice.

7 The 3-Week Plan

> If you start on **Wednesday 4 November**, Week 3 ends on **Tuesday 24 November**, and the mock tests run from **25 to 30 November**.

Week 1: Find the problems and fix the ear

Goal: know exactly where your marks go, and build the daily habit.

Day	Main task
1	**Full test**: C10 Test 1 (Tool F). Mark it. Fill in the Mistake Log carefully. This is your starting score.
2	Transcript Method on C10 T1 **Parts 1 & 2**. Practise the alphabet and number pairs (Section 3, Part 1) aloud.
3	Transcript Method on C10 T1 **Part 3**. Highlight all signal phrases. Read Section 4 twice.
4	Transcript Method on C10 T1 **Part 4**. Underline the lecture signposts.
5	**Full test**: C10 Test 2. Mark it and update the log.
6	Transcript Method on the **two weakest parts** of C10 T2.
7	**Review day:** count your log codes. Test yourself on every spelling word from this week. Light listening only.

Week 2: Part 3 and Part 4 power week

Goal: Part 3 score of 6/10 or more.

Day	Main task
8	C10 Test 3: **Parts 3 & 4 only** under test conditions, then Transcript Method on both.
9	C10 Test 4: **Parts 3 & 4 only**, then Transcript Method.
10	**Full test**: C11 Test 1.
11	Transcript Method on C11 T1 Part 3. Dictation on the same Part 3. Extra shadowing (10 min).
12	C11 Test 2: **Parts 3 & 4 only**, then Transcript Method. Focus on multiple-choice and matching tactics.
13	**Full test**: C11 Test 3.
14	**Review day:** count your log codes. Compare with Week 1: which code went down? Spelling test on all logged words.

Week 3: Exam simulation

Goal: full tests at 28–30+, with no Part 1 mistakes.

Day	Main task
15	**Full test**: C11 Test 4 (strict: no pausing, answer sheet, timed transfer).
16	Fix day: Transcript Method on every section where you lost 2+ marks.
17	**Full test**: C12 Test 1.
18	Fix day, as Day 16.
19	**Full test**: C12 Test 2.
20	Fix day + **final spelling test** on every word in your log. Rewrite each wrong one 3 times.
21	**Light day:** read your whole Mistake Log. Re-listen to the 2 hardest Part 3s with the script. Rest.

Weekly targets

End of	Full test score	Part 3 score	Spelling mistakes per test
Week 1	25–27	5/10	2 or fewer
Week 2	27–29	6/10	1 or fewer
Week 3	29–31	6–7/10	0–1

8 The Mock Test Phase (after Week 3)

Use **unseen** tests only: Cambridge 13 or 14 (or 17–19 if you have them).

Day	Task
Mock 1	Full test in exam conditions. If possible, do it at the same time of day as your real exam.
Next day	Transcript Method on lost sections only. Spelling review.
Mock 2	Full test.
Next day	Fix day.
Mock 3	Full test.
Before the exam	Light listening, read your Mistake Log, rest. **No new full test the day before the exam.**

Are you ready?

Mock results	What it means
2 of 3 mocks at **30+**	✅ Ready for band 7
Mocks at **28–29**	Close. Spend the remaining days only on your biggest log code.
Mocks below **27**	Look at the log: if most marks are SP/GR, do extra spelling; if most are LOST/DIS, do extra Part 3 transcript work.

9 Exam Day Checklist

Before each part:

☐ Read ahead during every pause. Don't go back to the previous section.

☐ Underline keywords and the word limit.

☐ Predict the word type (noun, number, plural?).

During the audio:

☐ Answers come **in order**. Stay with the audio.

☐ Two-question rule in Part 3. If you're lost, skip and move on.

☐ The **last** answer counts when the speaker corrects themselves.

Transfer / final check:

☐ CAPITAL LETTERS (paper test).

☐ Every spelling, letter by letter.

☐ Plural -s and -ed endings.

☐ Word limit (*NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS*).

☐ **No blanks.** Guess every missing answer.

10 Templates

Mistake Log

Date	Test	Q	❌ My answer	✅ Correct	Code	Why / what I learned

Weekly code count:

Week	SP	GR	WL	DIS	LOST	HEAR	VOC	Score
1								/40
2								/40
3								/40
Mocks								/40

21-Day Tracker

Day	Spelling	Dictation	Main task	Shadowing	Log	Score
1	☐	☐	☐ Full test C10 T1	☐	☐	/40
2	☐	☐	☐ Transcript P1–2	☐	☐	
3	☐	☐	☐ Transcript P3	☐	☐	
4	☐	☐	☐ Transcript P4	☐	☐	
5	☐	☐	☐ Full test C10 T2	☐	☐	/40
6	☐	☐	☐ Transcript weak parts	☐	☐	
7	☐	☐	☐ Review day	☐	☐	
8	☐	☐	☐ C10 T3 P3–4	☐	☐	/20
9	☐	☐	☐ C10 T4 P3–4	☐	☐	/20
10	☐	☐	☐ Full test C11 T1	☐	☐	/40
11	☐	☐	☐ Transcript P3 + extra shadowing	☐	☐	
12	☐	☐	☐ C11 T2 P3–4	☐	☐	/20
13	☐	☐	☐ Full test C11 T3	☐	☐	/40
14	☐	☐	☐ Review day	☐	☐	
15	☐	☐	☐ Full test C11 T4	☐	☐	/40
16	☐	☐	☐ Fix day	☐	☐	
17	☐	☐	☐ Full test C12 T1	☐	☐	/40
18	☐	☐	☐ Fix day	☐	☐	
19	☐	☐	☐ Full test C12 T2	☐	☐	/40
20	☐	☐	☐ Fix day + final spelling test	☐	☐	
21	☐	☐	☐ Light review	☐	☐	